killing of the policeman J.P. Saunders shows that he took part in the military faction as well as being in charge of the ideological wing.

The youthfulness of these revolutionaries was not without significance. The young were devoid of all hope for the future of India. This is clear from a manifesto produced in 1928 for the All-Punjab Naujawan Bharat Sabha in Amritsar. It was produced by Bhagwant Charan Vohra, the propagandist secretary of the HSRA. In it he proclaimed how 'the young bear the most inhuman tortures smilingly and face death without hesitation'.[1] After that, an emboldened HSRA published its manifesto in the following year in 1929. This contained the proclamation, 'Revolution is Law, Revolution is Order and Revolution is the Truth.' It continued, 'The youths of our nation have realised this truth'[2]—a commitment best encapsulated in the declaration Inquilab Zindabad[3] ('Long live the revolution'). The call for 'revolution' was not, however, to be misunderstood. It was not a single event. Nor was it necessarily violent. What it represented was an eternal, everlasting and permanent search for renewal and revitalization of the present. This is because, as Subhas Chandra Bose stated at the meeting of the All India Youth Congress in Calcutta in 1929, the youth were 'no longer content with handing over all responsibility to older leaders' and to be content 'following like dumb, driven cattle'.[4]

And so it came to be that it was in the person of Bhagat Singh that these popular dissidents acquired a form which could be venerated and passed down through oral narratives of the road to freedom in India. Whatever may have been the officially endorsed narrative of the 'centrality of nonviolence' in the anti-colonial movement before Independence, it is the centrality of Bhagat Singh to the lives and basic aspirations of the ordinary man in the Indian subcontinent that is significant today. They are the ones who are still struggling to make ends meet. This is why Chris Moffat has observed that when it comes to Bhagat Singh, it is '[t]he contours of this militant life – partisan commitment, unflinching action, heroic self-sacrifice – [that] continue to shape Bhagat Singh's ghost; acknowledging the weight of this legacy allows us to approach the enduring appeal to the revolutionary and the implications of his invocation today'.[5] In the words of Bipan Chandra,